

As much as we like playing with the newest smartphones, with each new review, we realise that there's little separating one phone from the other in a particular price segment. When you readers ask us for phone buying advice, we give you our recommendation based on the tests we have performed till date. But what's evident to us is that each question will invariably be answered with a set of 3-4 devices per price segment based on the buyer's requirements. There are some very important aspects that are often not covered in our reviews ratings though, and these can change our ratings drastically. Things such as service, support, updates and many others.

So, when we call this the ultimate buying guide for smartphones, it is because we factor in all these parameters. What we're doing here is taking all these parameters into consideration, and using the same to alter our ratings. These results will answer a bunch of questions that we often get from our readers.

HOW WE TESTED

Our review ratings are usually based on a scale of hundred that's further divided into four categories. Broadly speaking, that's amounts to 25 percent weightage each to performance, design, features and price. Of course, we break them down further in order to accommodate aspects such as camera, battery and many others, but that's basically it. So, when a phone gets 80 out of 100, it's amongst the best we've seen, while 60 and below would range from mediocre to worst. What's surprising though is how many phones lie around the 70-80 mark; satisfactory, but not very good.

This time though, we added six categories to our ratings, making the final score out of 200. The new parameters considered are screen repair cost, update cycles, return on investment, depreciation, availability of accessories and availability of the phone. While the update cycle includes how likely or quickly you will receive the next big update on your phone, return on investment is what you can get by reselling the phone after a year of using it. Availability covers things such as online, offline, flash sales and the infamous invites. We'll explain more as we go along.

We went around calling company service centres, tallying prices online, checking with phone buyers and so on and so forth. After adding these six parameters to our rating system, we saw a sea change in the new scores that emerged. A phone that was once marked 85 out of 100, suddenly dropped to a measly 76, while phones that were already in the 70-100 category, dropped to the 60-70 mark. As a result, we had a clearer idea of what phone would serve users the best, and we sincerely hope you would feel so too. The table ahead should give you an idea of how the scores change after adding each parameter.

WHY DID WE DO THIS?

When a consumer buys a phone, he's spending his hard earned money. Yes there are those who didn't work as hard as others, but it's still money that's yours and you tend to give it considerable thought. With the hordes of phone manufacturers in the market today, the consumer makes a

and one should buy a phone that he or she needs, not because there's a sale happening somewhere on the Internet. Yes, sales are opportune moments to make purchases, but most consumers don't realise that their smartphones can last much longer than what they have been led to believe.

One of the main reasons for people buying phones when they don't need to is that prices have come down. But a more important reason is because they probably made the wrong choice when buying phones the first time around.

BEFORE WE BEGIN...

It's important to introduce some of the phones that are currently amongst our top rated smartphones. We usually distinguish them based on price, but for the sake of this shootout, we'll sort them into phones that cost ₹5000-7000, 7000-10,000, 10,000-15,000, 15,000-20,000, 20,000-30,000, followed by flagship phones. This covers the most popular phones in the market,



Samsung Galaxy S6 Edge

very difficult choice when buying a smartphone, and more often than not, ends up buying the wrong phone and suffering as a consequence.

Furthermore, India is the hottest market in the world right now and everyone wants a piece of it. Needless to say, there are a bunch of companies that simply want to get a piece of the action, and spare little thought for after sales support and other aspects that, as Indians, we tend to hold in high regard. In addition, the trend for a while has been to sell products that the consumer will scrap in a year or less, in the name of 'upgrades'. In other words, planned obsolescence.

To be very frank, this is simply wrong. A smartphone today is a powerful device

and presents an ideal scenario for the reader to make his or her own judgement for the phone that he or she is buying.

Furthermore, before we start talking about the new elements that we took into consideration, it's important to note some of the top rated smartphones we have right now, based on the tests we have performed in the past.

For the flagship segment, this includes the Samsung Galaxy S6, Apple iPhone 6 and the LG G4. In the ₹20,000-30,000 segment, phones such as the OnePlus One, Honor 6 Plus, Asus Zenfone 2 (4GB RAM) and the Moto X (2nd Gen) were considered. Next, the ₹15,000-20,000 segment consists of phones such as the Asus Zenfone 2